1 Evidence Lab

Footprints and mystery powder · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 1**

11 min: 1 explain / 8 do / 2 hand over and reset | Medium energy | Arrive 1:05

SAY

"Every footprint tells a story. Measure twice. Then let's find out what that powder is."

Run it

1. Each detective measures the footprint (under the sheet protector) in cm. The squad agrees on **one** number.
2. Reveal the shoe-size chart. 27 cm = size 10. They write it in the case file.
3. Powder test: a pinch of each labeled powder on the tray, one pipette of vinegar each. Which fizzes? (Baking soda.)
4. Test the EVIDENCE powder. It fizzes. "So it's baking soda. Interesting. Remember that at Station 2."
5. At the bell: hand over the sealed **CLUE 1** envelope for this squad. Wipe the tray. Refill powder cups.

Fixes

- Measurements disagree: measure heel to toe together, once.
- Fast squad: lift a fingerprint off a cup with pencil graphite and tape.
- Kid won't touch powder: they're the recorder who writes the case file.

Say "candy" until Video 1 has played. Say "squishies" after.

Every squad arrives knowing what the whole room knows. Don't get ahead of the story.

Bin

- Footprint sheet + clear sheet protector
- 5 rulers, pencils
- Shoe-size chart
- 3 labeled powder cups + EVIDENCE cup (baking soda)
- Vinegar cup, 4 pipettes, rimmed tray
- Paper towels, wipes
- 4 CLUE 1 envelopes (one per squad)
- Backup Wanted sketch sheets

2 Ghostbuster Lab

Fizz open the evidence · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 2**

11 min | High energy | Arrive 1:05



> **SAY**
> "These ghosts are holding evidence hostage. The only thing they can't survive is vinegar. One syringe each. Bust them."

Run it

1. Five ghosts in the bin, one per detective. Each gets a syringe of green vinegar.
2. Bust the ghost until it fizzes apart and the word slip appears. Sleeves up.
3. The squad lays out the five words and reads the sentence: **"SEEN IN HALL AT 2:15."** Write it in the case file.
4. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 2** envelope (same sentence, sealed, for the file). Scoop out the residue, set five fresh ghosts.

Fixes

- Ghost won't break: more vinegar, poke it with the syringe tip.
- Kid doesn't want to touch it: they're the reader who assembles the words.
- Words out of order: "Read it like a sentence. Where does SEEN go?"

Mess control

Tablecloth under the bin. Fizz stays in the bin. The residue is harmless but keep sleeves up and wipes within reach.

Bin

- 25 baking-soda ghosts, in muffin tins
- Pitcher of green vinegar
- 6 syringes (one spare)
- Big under-bed bin as the lab tray
- Tablecloth, paper towels, wipes
- 4 CLUE 2 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

3 The Cipher Room

Ransom note and invisible ink · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 3**



11 min | Calm station | Arrive 1:10

> **SAY**
> "The thief left a note and thinks we can't read it. Prove them wrong. Then check the paper again. Thieves always leave something behind."

Run it

1. Hand the squad **their** ransom note (A Nightshade, B Raven, C Specter, D Ember) and the Pigpen key. They decode together, splitting the words. About 4 minutes.
2. Once decoded: "Now sweep the blacklight across the whole page."
3. The highlighter P.S. appears: **"SNAGGED MY ORANGE SWEATER ON THE SHELF. WORTH IT."** Write it in the case file.
4. Each detective writes a one-line secret message in highlighter on a card to take home.
5. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 3** envelope. Collect the note and key.

Hints and fixes

- Two free hints per squad. Make them ask.
- Stuck: give them the first word.
- Fast: they write a coded message for the next squad to solve.
- Let a quiet kid hold the blacklight.

Answers

- **A · Nightshade:** YOU WILL NEVER FIND IT DETECTIVES
- **B · Raven:** THE JAR IS MINE NOW NICE TRY
- **C · Specter:** STOP LOOKING IT IS GONE FOREVER
- **D · Ember:** YOU ARE GETTING COLDER DETECTIVES

Bin

- 4 ransom notes (A to D), P.S. already written in highlighter
- Pigpen key, printed large
- Pencils, white cards, yellow highlighters
- 2 blacklight flashlights
- Dark box (shoebox with a hand hole) if the room can't dim
- 4 CLUE 3 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

4 The Mummy Witness

Wrap and escape relay · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 4**

11 min | High energy | Arrive 1:05



> **SAY**
> "I am the witness. I saw everything. But I only speak to mummies. Wrap me."

Run it

1. **Round 1 (2 min):** the whole squad wraps YOU head to toe, eyes and mouth free. Timer on. Then you "talk": "The witness box. Only a mummy may open it."
2. **Round 2 (60 sec each, pairs):** a partner wraps a detective, who tears free and hobbles to the witness box line. Everyone who wants a turn gets one.
3. A mummy opens the box and takes the statement addressed to **their** squad (don't let them grab all four). They read it aloud. Each one is different; all four mean "the thief loves squishies." Write it in the case file.
4. "Detectives, bag the evidence." All paper in the trash bag before the bell.
5. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 4** envelope. New rolls out.

Fixes

- Kid doesn't want to be wrapped: wrapper or timekeeper. Both count.
- Running out of paper: one roll per pair.
- Best-wrapped, fastest, and funniest mummy all get a shout-out.

What each statement means

- **Nightshade:** squeezed one, whispered "so satisfying"
- **Raven:** squeezed one, squeezed another, giggled
- **Specter:** knew exactly which one was the avocado
- **Ember:** hugged the jar like a puppy

Bin

- 14 rolls of the cheapest toilet paper
- Trash bags, stopwatch
- Witness box with 4 labeled statements
- Tape for the start line, 10-foot hobble course
- 4 CLUE 4 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

FL

Floater / Photographer

Door, badges, restocks, photos, the hidden tags

Arrive 1:00 · Whole party



Before 1:30

- Crime-scene tape on the door frame (door stays usable). LED candle at each station.
- Cauldron and the Evidence Locker (under a cloth) by the Chief's desk.
- Badges, wristbands, and case files on the door table.

Timeline

1. **1:30** Door: badge and squad wristband for each detective (list from the Chief). Point them to their starting station: Nightshade 1, Raven 2, Specter 3, Ember 4.
2. **1:38 to 2:28** Rotations: bathroom runs in pairs, restock stations (TP, vinegar, wipes), photos of each station (check the opt-out list first).
3. **Each bell:** dim the lights while the Detective plays the video; back up to "dim" when it ends.
4. **Rotation 3 (2:04):** hide the 20 highlighter-marked evidence tags around the room: under desks, inside books, under chairs. Nobody notices; they're busy.
5. **2:28** Deliberation: lights up. Snacks by squad if food is approved. Open the Wanted Poster table. Collect warrants into the cauldron.
6. **2:40** Warrants read, Video 4 plays. Hand 3 blacklight flashlights to each squad. Stand by the lit hallway door during lights-out.
7. **2:48** Lights up. The Chief brings the Jar out. You run the trade: one tag, one squishy (candy layer first if there is one).
8. **2:55** Group photo with badges. Strike stations with the leads. Trash out. Tablecloths rolled and tossed.

Bin

- Badges, wristbands, case files
- Spare TP, spare wipes, trash bags
- 20 evidence tags (highlighter-marked)
- 12 blacklight flashlights
- The EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy (goes to the Detective before 1:30)
- Camera or phone, photo opt-out list
- Squad list with starting stations

The one thing that can't slip

The 20 tags must be hidden before 2:40. If rotation 3 gets away from you, hide them during rotation 4.

You are the only adult without a station. Everyone will ask you for things.

DET

The Detective's cue card

Opening, the live beat after Video 1, the finale lines



Room parent · Trench coat, clipboard

1:30 · THE OPENING (LIGHTS OFF, 90 SECONDS MAX)

"Detectives, we have a situation. At 2:15 yesterday, the Party Candy Jar, the one you have been staring at for a week, disappeared from that shelf. The door was locked. The window was shut. Somebody on this staff knows something. We have four suspects. Three of them have recorded statements, and you'll hear from them as the investigation unfolds. The fourth, the Custodian, declined to comment. Make of that what you will. We have four pieces of evidence, and exactly one hour before the trail goes cold. Your squad has a case file. Fill it in. Clear the innocent and you'll know who did it. Chief _____ has assured me she is not a suspect. Let's begin."

1:49 · RIGHT AFTER VIDEO 1 (THE PRINCIPAL)

Let the room react for five seconds. Then: "Did... did the Principal just say squishies?" Reach into the coat. Pull out the EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy. "Recovered from under that shelf this morning. I assumed it was unrelated." Turn to the Chief. "Chief. What exactly was in that jar?" *The Chief, flustered: "Candy. ...Mostly. Candy-adjacent."* Back to the room: "Detectives. That jar was never candy. Open your case files. Cross out 'candy.' Write 'squishies.' This changes nothing about the evidence and everything about the motive. Rotate."

2:02 AND 2:15 · AFTER VIDEOS 2 AND 3

One line each, then the bell. "The Gym Teacher does not understand squishies. Noted. Rotate." / "Check their feet. Hm. Rotate."

2:40 · WARRANTS AND THE FINAL STATEMENT

Pull each warrant from the cauldron and read it aloud: "Squad Nightshade accuses... the Chief." The Chief protests: "This is outrageous. I'm the Chief." You: "There is one more statement. It was recorded under protest." Play Video 4. When it ends: "Detectives, you heard her. A very special light. In one minute the lights go out for three minutes. Flashlights to the squads. Every detective finds one tag. Then we open the Jar."